Where the Evidence Goes Cold: A Scoping Review of Gendered Harms in Pakistan's Climate Displacement, from Monsoon Floods to Mountain Winters

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Introduction

Pakistan's 2022 and 2025 floods displaced millions. UN agencies warned of rising gender-based violence, child marriage and unmet maternal needs, and studies documented menstrual hardship in relief camps. Yet attention centres on lowland summer floods. In Pakistan's high mountains, glacial-lake floods and long freezing winters meet menstrual stigma, and little is known about these communities. Nepal's chhaupadi deaths from cold and smoke show how lethal that combination can be. This review maps what is known and unknown about harassment, gender-based violence and menstrual health in Pakistan's climate displacement, to inform SDGs 5, 3, 13 and 10.

Methodology

A rapid scoping review was run on 12–13 November 2026. Forty-two structured queries (2010–2026) across Crossref, Europe PMC (which includes PubMed), DOAJ and DataCite returned 3,799 records. Titles and abstracts were screened against three criteria: a climate hazard or displacement, a gendered harm, and a Pakistan setting. Targeted searches added grey literature: UN situation reports, a human-rights commission assessment, ICIMOD and university outputs. Each included item was coded by hazard, region, season, harm domain and evidence type. Documented chhaupadi deaths in Nepal served as a comparative reference for cold-season menstrual risk.

Findings, Outcomes and Implications

Fifty-five items met the criteria; 31 appeared in 2024–2026. Thirty-two concerned summer monsoon floods, mainly in Sindh and Punjab. Maternal health dominated (26 items). Seven covered mountain regions: one addressed menstrual health, none violence or harassment. No item examined displacement in winter; one national study tested cold exposure, on birth weight. Harassment was documented directly in two sources, transgender survivors in one, and child marriage in no primary study. Gender-responsive climate action must fund youth-led research on cold-season displacement, menstrual safety and harassment in mountain communities.

SDGs: 5, 3, 13, 10. Evidence table (55 coded items) available on request.